

Reflection

This internship was different from anything experienced in a classroom. The environment, the pace, the complexity of working inside a real institution like the European Commission were things that could not have been prepared for in advance. From the first week, it became clear that the rules of a school project do not apply in here. Decisions take longer, involves with more people and can have consequences to the project.

The biggest surprise was how difficult something looking simple could turn out to be. The occupancy indicator showing whenever a room is free or not went through more rounds of feedback than any other element and was still being refined in the last weeks of the internship. Every person who looked at it saw it differently. Some found the colors unclear, others did not understand at all, few did were confused how it fully functioned until it was explained. That taught me that in a real project, designs are never about what looks good mostly but more about what makes sense to the people who actually use it every day.

One thing that made me see the whole project differently was during a conversation with my mentor towards the end of the internship. I was confused and frustrated about not having access to API and be able to test it with real data, he told me that my job was not to develop everything from scratch but to analyze the problem, think it through, and propose specific solutions. That perspective made me step back and a lot of pressure took off and made me realize how much had actually been achieved for the European Commission. A fully tested design, a working demo, a clear technical path, a team that supported this project, and it had been reached.

The API access situation was the most stressful part of the internship. Multiple tries were made to find a solution like visiting the IT helpdesk, trying alternative network routes, asking colleagues for help. None of them worked. Looking back, the access request should have been asked at the beginning of the internship, and not have it planned as a next step once the fronted was made.

If this internship could be done again, I would start the API access process in the beginning of the weeks rather than wait as a next step once the front end was done. Also test the prototype on a real hardware, because the panels behave differently and have different screen sizes from a laptop browser. Having the hardware sooner and test on it, will save more time and find problems early.

This internship changed the way I approach the development. I now think more carefully about the people who will use what I build, the real challenge in a large institution is navigating the people, the approvals, the constraints around it, and the decisions that creates what the code is even allowed to do.

Looking back, the most important skill this internship developed was not just technical skill, but to learn how to work inside a large institution where every decision depends on multiple teams, approvals from different departments, and sometimes issues with priorities. The code and the design were the straightforward part. Understanding who needs to be informed, who needs to approve, and in what order, turned out to be challenging. That is something a classroom project cannot really teach but learn it from experience.